

Galega officinalis (Fabaceae)

Goat's Rue

Description Bushy perennial growing to about 3 ft (1 m) in height. Goat's rue has compound leaves with lance-shaped leaflets and delicate pink pea-type flowers on terminal spikes, and produces red-brown seed pods in autumn.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Asia and continental Europe, and naturalized in Britain, goat's rue grows in damp and low-lying areas. It is harvested in summer.



Goat's rue was once taken to treat the plague.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Goat's rue contains alkaloids (including galegine), lectins, flavonoids, and tannins. Galegine strongly reduces blood-sugar levels.

History & Folklore Formerly used as a treatment for the plague, goat's rue has been widely cultivated as a cattle feed.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Today, goat's rue is chiefly used as an anti-diabetic herb, having the ability to reduce blood-sugar levels. It is not a substitute for conventional drugs, but can be valuable in the early stages of type 2 diabetes and is best used as an infusion. The herb has the effect of increasing breast-milk production. It is also a useful diuretic.

Caution Use as part of the treatment of diabetes only under professional supervision.

Galipea officinalis
syn. *G. cusparia* (Rutaceae)

Angostura

Description Evergreen tree growing to 49 ft (15 m) with grey bark, shiny bright green leaflets, and foul-smelling flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Angostura is native to some Caribbean islands and to tropical South America. The bark is gathered throughout the year.

Part Used Bark.

Constituents Angostura bark contains bitter principles, quinoline alkaloids including cusparine, and 1–2% volatile oil. The alkaloids have antimicrobial activity against the tuberculosis bacillus.

History & Folklore Angostura is a traditional tonic and fever remedy in South America, used chiefly for digestive infections. Native Amazonians also use the plant as a fish poison. Angostura has been used as a source of "bitters," although it is unknown whether it is an ingredient of the cocktail flavoring bearing its name as the drink's composition is a trade secret.

Medicinal Actions & Uses A strong bitter with tonic properties, angostura stimulates the stomach and digestive tract as a whole. It is antispasmodic and is reported to act on the spinal nerves, helping in paralytic conditions. Angostura is typically given for weak digestion, and is considered valuable as a remedy for diarrhea and dysentery. In South America, it is sometimes used as a substitute for cinchona (*Cinchona* spp., p. 80) to control fevers.

Caution Use under professional guidance only.

Galium aparine (Rubiaceae)Cleavers,
Goose Grass

Description Straggling, square-stemmed annual growing to a height of 4 ft (1.2 m) with whorls of lance-shaped leaves, clusters of small white flowers, and small, round, green fruit with hooked prickles.

Habitat & Cultivation Common throughout Europe and North America, cleavers is found in many other temperate regions, including in Australia. It grows prolifically in gardens and along roadsides, and is gathered when just about to flower in late spring.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Cleavers contains iridoids (including asperuloside), polyphenolic acids, anthraquinones (only in the root), alkanes, flavonoids, and tannins. Asperuloside is a mild laxative.

History & Folklore The name cleavers refers to the plant's ability to cling (or cleave) to fur or clothing. Dioscorides, a Greek physician of the 1st century CE, considered it useful for countering weariness, and described how shepherds used the stems to make sieves for straining milk.



Dried aerial parts

Medicinal Actions & Uses A valuable diuretic, cleavers is often taken for skin diseases such as seborrhea, eczema, and psoriasis; for swollen lymph glands; and as a general detoxifying agent in serious illnesses such as cancer. The plant is commonly prepared in the form of an infusion, but for conditions such as cancer, it is best taken as a juice, which is strongly diuretic. The juice and the infusion are also taken for kidney stones and other urinary problems.

Research According to French research (1947), an extract of the plant appears to lower blood pressure.

Related Species The Mexican *G. orizabense* is used by the Mazatecs to treat intestinal parasites and to relieve fever. *G. umbrosum* from New Zealand has been used to treat gonorrhea. See also lady's bedstraw (*G. verum*, following entry).

Galium verum (Rubiaceae)

Lady's Bedstraw

Description Short, sprawling perennial growing to 32 in (80 cm). Has whorls of narrow dark green leaves and tufts of very small bright yellow flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Found throughout Europe and western Asia, and naturalized in North America, lady's bedstraw thrives in dry meadows, along roadsides, and in wayside places. It is gathered when in flower in summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Lady's bedstraw contains iridoids (including asperuloside), flavonoids, anthraquinones, alkanes, and rennin.

History & Folklore The name of this pleasant-scented herb derives from its traditional use as a stuffing for mattresses. In medieval times, it was used as a "strewing" herb on floors. Lady's bedstraw curdles milk and gives a yellow color to cheese produced from the curd. In his *Irish Herbal* (1735), K'Eogh states, "when applied to burns, the crushed flowers alleviate inflammation, and when applied to wounds, they can heal them."



Lady's bedstraw is used as a diuretic.